

1968 in France. Investors moved assets to Switzerland when they regarded conditions elsewhere as less predictable.

Perrenoud identified capabilities that persisted throughout these different periods, namely discretion that went beyond banking secrecy, knowledge of international markets, long-term thinking, and coordination. The federal government defended the country's financial interests abroad, while professional associations coordinated between the various financial actors. Perrenoud thus accounts for Switzerland's position in terms of institutions and decisions, rather than fixed national characteristics. While political and monetary stability created favorable conditions, it was banks, diplomats, and professional organizations that took advantage of these conditions to build a durable international financial center.

2.2 Building Trust through Gold Infrastructure

Switzerland's position in the global gold market shows how trust can be built through laws, production standards, certification, and custody. Paul Noel, a precious-metals entrepreneur and founder of Swiss One Plus, traced this position to investments made by Swiss banks and refiners over more than a century.

According to Noel, Credit Suisse, SBS, and UBS invested directly in the refinement of precious metals as they expanded their wealth-management activities. They financed production lines and laboratories, while refiners adopted common specifications for the weight and purity of investment bars. Switzerland consequently developed the capacity both to process gold at scale and to certify the resulting product.

Noel placed particular importance on Swiss assaying law, citing legislation governing sworn assayers that dates to 1880, which emphasizes their personal responsibility for the certifications they sign. Buyers require confirmation that a given bar contains gold in the stated quantity and purity. Noel argued that this legal accountability helped strengthen confidence in Swiss certification, thus contributing to the international acceptance of Swiss-refined bars. He also pointed out that

four of the world's five largest refiners are in Switzerland, that Switzerland produces about 80 percent of internationally recognized Good Delivery investment bars, and that its refineries can process up to 4,000 tons per year. He distinguished this domestic capacity from the country's annual gold imports, because Swiss facilities also reprocess existing bars that are in need of purification and certification.

The issue of custody adds another layer. Noel pointed to the protection of property, transport networks, secure facilities, and the repurposing of former defense sites to store precious metals and data, while also stressing that a secure vault does not determine the investor's rights. He distinguished allocated gold from segregated gold, stressing the need to establish which metal an investor owns, how ownership is recorded, who can move it, and how it can be withdrawn.

Digital representation makes these questions even more urgent. A token representing one gram of gold does not necessarily confer ownership of an identifiable gram, since it may represent a fractional claim on a larger bar. Investors must therefore understand their legal rights in relation to the underlying metal and what happens if an intermediary fails.

Gold itself does not depend on Switzerland. The country's contribution is the infrastructure around it: refining, verification, custody, legal ownership, and secure transfers. Noel's proposal for Zurich to become a clearing center for physical gold situated between Western and Asian markets represents an extension of this model.

2.3 The History of Private Banking and the Future of Legacy Houses

At the time of the interview, Frank Häusler was Chief Investment Officer at Dreyfus Sons & Co Ltd, Banquiers, a family-owned private bank that was founded in Basel in 1813. In his view, the bank's more than two centuries of history matter only if they help it to make better decisions for clients today.

Häusler starts with the client rather than with an investment product. In the interview, he described arriving at first meetings with a blank sheet of paper and asking the client what they want to achieve. The answer could have to do with investments, but it could also concern who

controls the wealth, whose interests it should serve, and how arrangements should be perpetuated across generations. This is what distinguishes a private bank from platforms providing fast access, competitive prices, and effective digital interfaces. When a client's needs go beyond a predefined service, it is up to the bank to connect investment decisions to their broader financial and family circumstances.

This same principle informs Häusler's definition of long-term investing. Investors cannot know what economic, political, or market risks will emerge. Portfolios and relationships should therefore remain viable under conditions that were not foreseen when they were created. New information matters when it changes the assumptions behind a strategy, but most headlines do not meet this threshold.

While institutional history can improve judgment, Häusler distinguished experience from nostalgia. Experience becomes useful when previous wars, crises, inflation, technological changes, and monetary shifts provide a perspective on seemingly unprecedented events.

He applies the same test to technology. Artificial intelligence, digital assets, and tokenization should be adopted when they improve client outcomes or operations without compromising risk management, governance, or custody. For example, dividing a hotel into one million tokens creates smaller ownership units, but does not itself create buyers, and thus liquidity.

Client expectations are also changing. Häusler finds that younger clients are better informed and more willing to question decisions. They expect faster access and clearer explanations of what the bank is doing and why it is appropriate to their circumstances. One principle remains constant, namely that the bank is managing someone else's money. Fiduciary responsibility requires discretion, informed judgment, and decisions that can be explained. For Häusler, a long history matters when it helps the bank make better decisions in uncertain circumstances without hampering useful innovation.

2.4 The Evolving Responsibilities of Wealth Advisers

Roger Hartmann described a wealth-management profession that has undergone a transformation over the course of his four decades in finance. When he entered banking in 1983, a relationship manager could still work largely on his own, relying on his personal knowledge, experience, and judgment. As the financial circumstances of wealthy clients have become increasingly complex, Hartmann now considers that model inadequate. The adviser has shifted from being an individual expert to a coordinator of specialized expertise.

Several developments explain this shift: The range of asset classes has expanded, wealthy clients increasingly hold financial interests across countries, taxation and asset structuring require expertise beyond portfolio management, and diversification now entails making decisions across both assets and geographies. A single adviser can no longer master every field that is relevant to the client.

For this reason, Hartmann described the modern adviser as the chief financial officer for private clients. The adviser must understand the client's overall financial position, identify when specialist expertise is required, and connect the answers given by specialists to decisions made in other areas of the client's affairs. A tax, investment, or structuring expert can solve a particular problem, but it is the adviser who must ensure that these solutions are integrated into a coherent whole.

Switzerland's international orientation has reinforced this role. Hartmann links the geographic outlook of Swiss private bankers to Switzerland's small domestic market. Advisers had to follow clients and markets abroad, thus reducing their dependence on a single national market, while increasing the amount of legal, regulatory, and financial knowledge required in order to give cross-border advice.

In the same period, the amount of time dedicated to direct contact with clients has come under pressure. Hartmann argued that independent wealth managers and multi-family offices retain an advantage when they can devote more time to clients, estimating that relationship managers in some banks spend less than half of their work time with clients and, in some institutions, as little as 30 percent. Responsibilities



have expanded, while the time available for giving advice has contracted.

Hartmann sees artificial intelligence as providing a way to reverse part of this imbalance. His notion of a “digital twin” refers to technology that can perform the necessary administrative and analytical work on an ongoing basis. AI should augment rather than replace the adviser, freeing up time to understand clients and coordinate specialists.

The purpose of advice remains the same, namely to help clients diversify assets, control risk, and make financial decisions. What has changed is the method. The adviser now works through specialists, across jurisdictions, and with technology. Hartmann’s private CFO must connect expertise in taxation, investment, and structuring so that decisions made in one area remain consistent with the client’s broader financial affairs.

2.5 Digital Assets Enter Wealth Management

Alexander Petoud described two industries moving toward each other: Crypto is adopting wealth-management practices, while traditional finance is incorporating digital assets. Petoud, Chief Commercial Officer of SwissBorg, spent sixteen years in traditional banking and wealth management before joining the company. He expects the distinction between the two sectors to diminish as digital assets enter conventional portfolios and financial products increasingly make use of digital infrastructure.

Client demand already reflects this transition. Petoud recalled that five years ago, prospective investors often asked which token could be expected to multiply rapidly in value. Today, they ask how to integrate crypto into their wealth, how to obtain exposure without managing the operational process themselves, and how to transfer digital assets to the next generation. These are questions connected to portfolio construction, access, and succession rather than short-term token selection.

SwissBorg has adapted its offering accordingly. At first, the company developed primarily thanks to retail clients, but it reports growing

interest from family offices, pension funds, and other institutional investors. These investors may be seeking crypto exposure without wanting to open an account on a crypto platform and execute transactions directly. SwissBorg has therefore created an Actively Managed Certificate with an ISIN that can be purchased through an existing bank, broker, or family office. This structure connects crypto-native investment expertise with established wealth-management distribution infrastructure.

The investment horizon is changing as well. Petoud distinguished wealth management from platforms designed mainly for short-term trading, describing client relationships that extend over five, ten, or fifteen years, with portfolios that are intended to pass through market cycles. According to Petoud, SwissBorg is applying a traditional Swiss private-banking philosophy to digital assets.

Tokenization could further weaken the boundary between the two sectors. Traditional institutions are adding digital assets, while crypto companies are considering products linked to conventional securities. If shares and other assets are issued or represented on digital infrastructure, it may increasingly be an asset's economic characteristics that are relevant, rather than whether it originated in traditional or crypto finance.

Regulation will influence the speed of this convergence. Petoud views stronger rules as necessary to ensure investor confidence and presents SwissBorg's MiCA authorization as important for the European market, while also warning that excessive costs can deter smaller firms and innovation. AI and blockchain may become more important in portfolio management, but Petoud says accountability for financial decisions must remain with people. He therefore expects digital and traditional finance to become progressively more integrated.

2.6 What Defines the Swiss Wealth-Management Model?

The Day 1 closing panel presented Swiss wealth management as a combination of capabilities developed over time. Alexander Petoud emphasized service and long experience, Frank Häusler brought

together legacy, reliability, and innovation, Roger Hartmann stressed global reach, and Marc Perrenoud identified history, discretion, specialization, and knowledge of international markets. Perrenoud combined these perspectives by identifying a common structure: Switzerland's strength lies in combining several different pillars, rather than allowing one to dominate.

Particular emphasis was placed on long-term thinking. Petoud considered it a durable pillar of Swiss business practice, while Häusler connected it to service quality, knowledge, and expertise, which take time to build. His broader point is that portfolios and relationships should be structured for a future that cannot be predicted. Long-term thinking therefore means preparing for uncertainty, rather than making predictions.

The panel then examined how these capabilities respond to disruption. Häusler associated the 2008 crisis and changes in banking secrecy with greater transparency and competition. Hartmann saw 2008 as a fundamental transformation, emphasizing the ability to adapt. Finally, Perrenoud situated recent disruptions within a longer history: While Switzerland possessed certain advantages in 1918, in 1946, and at later turning points, it was particular decisions that determined whether these advantages were strengthened or weakened. The country's legacy created possibilities; decisions determined the outcome.

The panel then asked which functions AI can perform and which ones still require human judgment. Petoud argued that advisers remain better equipped to understand personal and family situations, biases, and signals in human interaction, while AI can already perform parts of investment analysis and portfolio work. Häusler likewise expressed doubt that AI can reproduce complex human interaction in a way that makes clients feel heard. Hartmann expects AI to augment human advisers. Perrenoud cautioned against single-cause explanations: Switzerland's financial development was shaped by professional, economic, cultural, religious, and political factors, and he expects human factors to remain important as AI develops.

The speakers also identified conditions that could affect Switzerland's competitiveness. Häusler argued that the country should connect its existing foundations with innovation, while Hartmann warned that other financial centers have agile regulators and close dialogue between regulators and industry: Switzerland could lose momentum if that dialogue weakens. Petoud added data ownership as a further condition,

arguing that individuals should decide whether their data is shared or monetized.

Perrenoud articulated a powerful synthesis in his description of heritage as a culture of using strengths developed over centuries and knowing when to adapt them to circumstances. He rejected the idea that being a financial center is part of Switzerland's "DNA," since financial history is the result of human decisions. For this reason, the panel supported a cumulative model, in which international experience, discretion, long-term thinking, service, specialization, stability, and adaptation reinforce one another, but none is sufficient on its own. Switzerland's future success depends on how institutions combine and renew these capabilities as circumstances change.

2.7 What Day 1 Established

Taken as a whole, the discussion on Day 1 provided support for a cumulative understanding of the Swiss wealth-management model. International reach, discretion, long-term thinking, specialist infrastructure, service, and institutional stability were built up through various historical processes. No single factor explains Switzerland's current position. Instead, they gain value from being combined: standards make custody credible; lengthy experience improves judgment only when it informs present decisions; international orientation expands expertise but also places increased demands on advisers; and innovation matters when it can be integrated without weakening responsibility or control.

This cumulative view also introduces the first constraint on the argument made in this white paper. Heritage is a resource, not a guarantee. Perrenoud's historical account repeatedly returned to decisions made under changing circumstances, while Häusler, Hartmann, and Petoud described current institutions adapting established practices to new client needs and technologies. Day 1 therefore supplied the initial proposition for the rest of the paper, namely that Switzerland's advantage consists in capabilities that can reinforce one another, but that these capabilities remain valuable only when institutions continue to use and adapt them in a deliberate way.

2.7 What Day 1 Established

Speakers

Dr. Marc Perrenoud

Takeaway 1

The Swiss financial center is a historical construction. Institutions and decisions, rather than inherent characteristics, are responsible for its present position.

Takeaway 2

International crises repeatedly strengthened Switzerland's role as a safe financial center. Political, monetary, and financial stability attracted foreign capital during periods of international instability. WW1 and WW2 were tipping points.

Takeaway 3

Discretion and long-term thinking became core capabilities of Swiss wealth management. The state and professional associations helped preserve these capabilities and defend Swiss financial interests.

Paul Noel

Takeaway 1

Trust is institutionalized through standards, certification, and legal accountability.

Takeaway 2

Switzerland built a complete infrastructure for gold, from refining to custody and protection of ownership.

Takeaway 3

Swiss leadership is systemic: law, industrial capacity, infrastructure, and governance reinforce one another.

Frank Häusler

Takeaway 1

Long-term thinking means preparing for uncertainty, not predicting the future.

Takeaway 2

Strong institutions combine continuity with adaptation: History supports judgment without preventing innovation.

Takeaway 3

Simplicity and discipline protect decision-making from complexity, headlines, and short-term pressures.

2.7 What Day 1 Established

Speakers

Roger Hartmann

Takeaway 1

The adviser has evolved from an individual expert to a private CFO.

Takeaway 2

Growing financial and cross-border complexity requires coordinated specialist expertise.

Takeaway 3

AI should augment the adviser, restoring time for clients, while human judgment and responsibility remain central.

Alexander Petoud

Takeaway 1

Crypto is moving from speculation to wealth management.

Takeaway 2

TradFi and crypto are converging from both directions through products, distribution, and tokenization.

Takeaway 3

Digital infrastructure changes delivery, not the need for long-term advice and human accountability.

Day Panel

Takeaway 1

Switzerland remains the historical reference center for international wealth management.

Takeaway 2

Its strength comes from combining capabilities: international expertise, discretion, long-term thinking, stability, service, and specialization.

Takeaway 3

These capabilities are cumulative, not innate: Past choices created them, and present choices determine whether they continue to strengthen.

